

Australian biofouling management requirements for non-commercial vessels

The Australian biofouling management requirements for non-commercial vessels (ABFMR-NCV) set out vessel operator obligations for the management of biofouling. These obligations apply when operating non-commercial vessels under biosecurity control within Australian territorial seas, in order to comply with the Biosecurity Act 2015. New proactive biofouling management options for non-commercial vessels will apply from 17 June 2026. Vessel owners who meet at least one of the options are less likely to experience the inconvenience of vessel intervention and inspection.

A non-commercial vessel is a vessel that is used, or is intended to be used, wholly for recreational purposes – for example, a yacht – whether or not crew are employed on the vessel.

Operators of all non-commercial vessels subject to biosecurity control must provide information relating to biofouling management through the mandatory pre-arrival report (PAR). This information is reported through the department's [Maritime and Aircraft Reporting System \(MARS\)](#). The PAR responses help us manage biosecurity risks associated with biofouling on non-commercial vessels.

Our biosecurity officers may check this information during a vessel inspection. Relevant documentary evidence must be available if we ask for it.

Non-commercial vessel operators who cannot demonstrate accepted biofouling management practices will be asked additional questions about how the vessel's biofouling has been managed. Biosecurity officers will assess the biosecurity risk associated with biofouling on the vessel and may take necessary actions to address unacceptable risk.

For information relating to commercial vessels, see [Australian biofouling management requirements for commercial vessels](#)

Proactive biofouling management options

Vessel operators can demonstrate proactive management of biofouling by implementing one of the three accepted biofouling management options:

Option 1: Implement an effective biofouling management plan and record book

If you report that you have implemented an effective biofouling management plan and record book for the vessel, you must be able to provide us with:

- a biofouling management plan (BFMP)
- a biofouling record book (BFRB).

The biofouling management plan and record book must meet the minimum standards set out in ABFMR-NCV to satisfy the requirements of option 1.

Biofouling management plan and record book

An effective biofouling management plan must be vessel specific and have sufficient detail for the operator to implement the specified biofouling management activities. The biofouling record book should contain a complete and up-to-date record of all biofouling management activities undertaken on the vessel and used with the management plan. The management plan and record book may be electronic or in hard copy and available for inspection on request.

Email biofouling@aff.gov.au to obtain a biofouling management plan example template.

Option 2: Clean all biofouling prior to arrival in Australian territory

You may report that the vessel has been cleaned of all biofouling (including niche areas) within an approved timeframe:

- Within 30 days prior to entering Australia.
- 15 or more days since cleaning occurred, if the vessel has not been stationary within 12 nautical miles of any land.

If you report this, the following documents must be available on request:

- a cleaning report
- supporting photographs and/or video.

The cleaning report and supporting evidence must meet the minimum standards set out in ABFMR-NCV to satisfy the requirements of option 2.

Option 3: Alternative biofouling management method approved by the department

If you report that the vessel has an alternative biofouling management method that has been approved by the department, the following documents must be available on request:

- department issued written approval, specific to the vessel and voyage
- any documents as specified in the department issued approval.

Approval of the alternative biofouling management method must be obtained from the department prior to arrival to meet the requirements of option 3.

Obtaining approval

The department will consider applications for an alternative biofouling management method if the vessel operator can provide:

- a proposed alternative method that appropriately manages the biosecurity risk associated with the vessel's biofouling
- sufficient evidence to substantiate the proposal.

Applications for an alternative biofouling management method must include:

- a completed and signed application form
- the most recent in-water inspection and cleaning reports
- evidence to support your application.

The application must be submitted to biofouling@aff.gov.au no later than 30 days prior to arrival in Australian territorial seas. The department may request further information to process the application.

Application for an alternative biofouling management method form

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Vessel operators that cannot demonstrate proactive biofouling management practices

A vessel operator that cannot demonstrate proactive biofouling management practices using one of the three accepted management options will be subject to additional questions during inspections to help identify potential biosecurity risk.

Australian biofouling management requirements

For more information on Australia's biofouling management requirements, see the [Biofouling resources page](#).

- [Australian biofouling management requirements for non-commercial vessels \(PDF 540 KB\)](#)
- [Australian biofouling management requirements for non-commercial vessel \(Word 1.7 MB\)](#)

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More information

Refer to the International Maritime Organization's guidance on [biofouling management for recreational boating](#) for information about how you can help protect against the risks of biofouling on your vessel.

Visit the [boat owners page](#) for more on how you can help prevent the spread of pests and diseases in our waterways.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/aircraft-vessels-military/vessels/marine-pest-biosecurity/biofouling/non-commercial-vessels-biofouling>